use for it is, therefore, "*mukti*"—freedom, freedom from the bonds of imperfection, freedom from death and misery.'

But here Vivekananda had a little surprise up his sleeve for the listening Westerners, particularly for those who thought of their God as a distant vision, or an aged and forbidding figure in the clouds with a white beard. 'And how to worship Him?' he asked of his God. 'Through love. He is to be worshipped as the one beloved, dearer than everything in this and the next life. This is the doctrine of love declared in the Vedas, and let us see how it is fully developed and taught by Krishna whom the Hindus believe to have been God incarnate on earth. He taught that a man ought to live in this world like a lotus leaf, which grows in water but is never moistened by water; so a man ought to live in the world—his heart to God and his hands to work.' For Vivekananda this selfless love for God was implicit in the teachings of the Bhagavad Gita. 'It is good to love God for hope of reward in this or the next world, but it is better to love God for love's sake; and the prayer goes: "Lord, I do not want wealth nor children nor learning. If it be Thy will, I shall go from birth to birth; but grant me this, that I may love Thee without the hope of reward —love unselfishly for love's sake."'

To Vivekananda, the answer to the question 'What is Hinduism?' could be reduced to the idea of realisation, of the union of *atman* and Brahman, the *moksha* taught by Advaita Vedanta: 'the whole object of [Hinduism] is by constant struggle to become perfect, to become divine, to reach God, and see God; and this reaching God, seeing God, becoming perfect even as the Father in Heaven is perfect, constitutes the religion of the Hindus…' He explained: 'There is something beyond even this fine body, which is the Atman of man, which has neither beginning nor end, which knows not what death is…I am already joined —from my very birth, from the very fact of my life—I am in *Yoga* [union] with that infinite life….'

From there, having explained Hinduism in terms that Westerners could grasp, Vivekananda firmly parted from their basic assumptions. He argued that the Hindu religion 'means realisation and nothing short of that. "Believe in the doctrine and you are safe" can never be taught to us, for we do not believe in that; you are what you make yourselves…